Grant Smith Ellis Court Log

USA v. Matthew Farwell - October 21, 2026

INTERIM / UNFINISHED - first checkpoint through 11:31:28 AM ET

About this report: This document reconstructs Grant Smith Ellis's contemporaneous courtroom reporting from his posts on X. Grant-authored reporting is reproduced as retrieved and organized chronologically by testimony/proceeding; editorial organization and known retrieval limitations are documented in the full Source & Editorial Notes at the end.

Day overview

Coverage cutoff	11:31:28 AM ET, October 21, 2026
Live-thread root	2112885317116059676
Retrieved reporting entries reproduced	50
Status	Interim / unfinished - first checkpoint

Opening, rulings, and pre-jury proceedings

8:34:49 AM ET | Status 2112885317116059676

Good morning from inside Boston's Moakley Federal Courthouse where I am seated and ready for the start of proceedings.

Yesterday, we learned that at least one Stoughton Police Officer other than Matthew Farwell was involved in a coverup of Sandra Birchmore's death.

Today, testimony from the DOJ's grooming expert is expected.

The live thread will begin below after 8:45AM when the parties enter the court.

Open original post on X

8:44:50 AM ET | Status 2112887837196722180

Okay, I have obtained a cookie and a coffee.

Judge has taken the bench.

We begin.

Open original post on X

8:45:48 AM ET | Status 2112888082059960709

"Counsel, just a few things before we get started. I went over the list of exhibits that were provided by the government. There was one, g-185, which my list said was a text chain but when I opened it it was another photo of Ms. Birchmore. If it's supposed to be a text chain, please send me a copy of it."

Farwell is seated at counsel table. Blue suit, green tie, light blue undershirt.

Open original post on X

8:47:36 AM ET | Status 2112888531911602613

"This exhibit, a consent to search by Mr. Pickard, any objection?"

"No, your honor."

"Your honor, 381 is a photo it was just mislabeled, to go back to the topic from earlier."

"So, counsel, is there a defense 403 argument about the number of photographs. I understand some of the photos, the one with the necklace for example, was being offered for another purpose. Why is 381 relevant?"

"381 depicts her arm in a sling. Ms. Birchmore had shoulder surgery in the summer of 2020 and she had shoulder pain in the fall of 2020. There are text messages suggesting that Ms. Birchmore had shoulder pain after her surgery and until her death and, given the position in which she was found, the government thinks the photo of her in a sling is relevant."

"Okay, I'll listen for that."

Open original post on X

8:50:13 AM ET | Status 2112889191591788565

"Your honor, for the defense, we'll get the reports Ms. Duval produced with regards to the DNA experts over to you tonight."

"Okay."

"Two other things, I got docket 366 which was Farwell''s motion to reconsider the admission of Q-10 and R-10, and I should say that there were a number of exhibits attached to that motion which I did have a chance to review. They were IEP reports, a psych assessment from the school district and one was from grade and one was from grade 11. I also got the government's

opposition, docket 367."

"Counsel, I appreciate the attachments and the filings but it doesn't change my rulings. Having read through the IEP's and the assessment, they largely relied, and in fact I think they use the phrase historically, is relying on Q-10, r_10, the prior assessment which I concluded is inadmissible. So, my ruling on that will stand."

"Your honor we understand, but we may ask to revisit again in the future."

"Okay."

Open original post on X

8:53:03 AM ET | Status 2112889906640920625

"Regarding docket 338 and the evidence of the affairs, for the reasons I articulated on Friday and Monday, the limits I am going to allow on this comport with the two prongs of 404 B and the probative value is not outweighed by unfair prejudice under 403. I will give a limiting instruction to the jury. Counsel, I looked at the First Circuit's pattern instruction which is 206 and I also considered circuit law, U.S. Vs Garcia-Sierra 1 circuit 2021, US Vs Randazzo, 1st Circuit 1996, US. Vs Escobar De Jesus, 1 Circuit 1999 and US V Doe 1 Circuit 2013, counsel this is what I propose to read;

Jurors I previously mentioned to you that certain evidence will be introduced that you can consider for one purpose but for no other purpose, and I will instruct you when that occurs. The expected testimony from this witness is one of those instances. You may not use this evidence to infer that because of Mr. Farwell's alleged character he carried out the acts alleged in this case. You may only use it to determine if he had the motive, state or mind or intent to commit the crimes charged against him. This is the only purpose for which you may use this evidence."

Open original post on X

8:54:57 AM ET | Status 2112890383772377568

"No objection to the instruction but we preserve out 404 B objection."

"Understood."

"The government would like the word 'plan,' as well."

"Defense objects."

"Counsel, I will say, the pattern instruction anticipates that there may be multiple purposes of special relevance one of them is plan or preparation for the commission of a crime. So counsel, just give me a moment."

"Not to interrupt your honor thoughts, but as to timeline, the word plan is not a viable option under 404 b."

"Mr. Fogerty?"

"Yes, your honor; we are offering this evidence to show Mr. Farwell did not engage in disguises on Feb 1st, shows that he had a [plan to commit a crime that day."

"Counsel, I think that's a correct statement here, just give me a moment."

Open original post on X

8:57:52 AM ET | Status 2112891117540671493

"So, counsel, just again looking at the pattern instruction and adjusting what I proposed, when I get to the sentence, "you may consider this evidence only for the limited purpose," I will amend that to say "only for the limited purpose of deciding of whether he acted according to a plan, or whether he had the motive, state of mind or intent necessary to commit the crimes charged against him." So I'll amend it in that way."

"Thank your honor."

"Defense notes it's objection."

"Thank you."

"Anything else?

"Nothing from the government."

"With one witness today there may be a single page from a Facebook return, this is Mc. McGrath, I think the issue that we had was pulling excepts from larger exhibits. So one of the exhibits is Ms. Birchmore's full 1,000 page Facebook return. 20,000 pages, I'm sorry, wow that's a lot. So, our thought was to pull a single page and note it as exhibit number dash a."

"That's fine."

Open original post on X

8:58:35 AM ET | Status 2112891297874735283

"Counsel, we are waiting for a few more jurors. We can stand in recess until we have all of the jurors. Who is the witness this morning?"

"This is going to be Stephanie Wait from the crime lab due to scheduling."

"Okay, once we have all of our jurors, please bring her into the courtroom. We stand in recess."

Recess!

Open original post on X

9:05:18 AM ET | Status 2112892988548685859

Jurors entering!

Open original post on X

Stephanie Waite - Massachusetts State Police Crime Lab

9:07:13 AM ET | Status 2112893468435435886

The witness takes the stand.

This is Stephanie Waite.

She is in the Criminalistics Unit of the state police crime lab.

Open original post on X

9:08:00 AM ET | Status 2112893668839542945

"What do you do during crime scene response?"

"I do biological testing or collection of evidence."

"Who decides if you do that?"

"The law enforcement officers who call us."

"What if you are not called to the scene?"

"Then the evidence can be sent to us later."

Open original post on X

9:09:03 AM ET | Status 2112893929351790676

"What is your job?"

"I am a forensic scientist."

"What is a forensic scientist?"

"A forensic scientist uses sciences to analyze physical evidence from crime scenes, and helps law

enforcement with that evidence during investigations."

Open original post on X

9:09:44 AM ET | Status 2112894102207390170

"You can test for the presence of skin cells?"

"I can' test for skin cells, but I can find that kind of data and send it off to another area of our lab."

"And you can test for biological fluids?"

"Yes, things like blood, semen, saliva and urine."

Open original post on X

9:10:36 AM ET | Status 2112894322282750335

"Is there in-house training required in your unit?"

"Yes, we have modules and units. We watch videos, we watch trained instructors, we practice the methods ourselves, then we take a test at the end of each unit. I passed each test."

Open original post on X

9:11:43 AM ET | Status 2112894600721403931

"Have you testified in court previously?"

"Yes, in state and federal court."

"Do you review the work of other people and do they review your work in the lab?"

"Yes, we use a peer-review system. They review the entire case file and ensure we have documented our results. Then we have an administrative review that is distinct and ensures the document has no typos, etc."

Open original post on X

9:12:23 AM ET | Status 2112894771949674918

"What types of items can you do testing on?"

"Clothing, types of weapons, anything like that, surfaces, water bottles, car door handles."

"What about skin cells?"

"I can collect those from almost anything that touches skin."

Open original post on X

9:13:51 AM ET | Status 2112895137558720882

"What do you do with those samples?"

"I collect them and save them for DNA testing?"

"Are you familiar with the case number for this matter?"

"Yes, it is 21-02589."

"Were you the person who looked at certain evidence submitted under the file?"

"Yes."

"You said earlier there are two ways you can collect evidence, going to the scene or getting evidence, were you asked to go to the scene in this case?"

"I was not."

"Did you receive evidence?"

"Yes, and evidence collection kit. Finger nail scrapings and a blood tube. Also a pair of underwear, and a ligature."

Open original post on X

9:14:46 AM ET | Status 2112895370640478640

"What is a known blood sample?"

"That is a blood tube that you would get for testing. They take the blood and put it into the tube and we can then use that to get a known DNA profile."

"From whom was the blood collected in this case?"

"Sandra Birchmore"

"And fingernail clippings?"

"Yes."

"And the underwear?"

"Yes."

Open original post on X

9:15:19 AM ET | Status 2112895507500826850

"Do you recall when you received those items of evidence in this case?"

"March 5, 2021. I didn't start work on them until March 11, 2021."

Open original post on X

9:16:02 AM ET | Status 2112895687918760382

"The right hand fingernail clippings, were those evidence number 2-3?"

"May I look at my notes? I don't recall."

"With the court's permission."

"Yes."

"Yes that's the right number."

Open original post on X

9:16:28 AM ET | Status 2112895798295871788

"Where were the swaps collected from Sandra Birchmore's body?"

"The vaginal cavity, the oral cavity, the perirenal area and the anus."

Open original post on X

9:17:47 AM ET | Status 2112896127364190484

"When should these swaps be collected?"

"Within 5 days, ideally."

"Why?"

"Because the evidence can be lost."

"How long can sperm cells survive inside a vaginal cavity?"

"For someone who is alive, 5 days. For someone who is dead, the literature says about 34 days."

"What about the oral cavity?"

"24 hours for someone who is alive. For someone is dead, about 4 days."

"When were the swaps collected form Ms. Birchmore's body?"

"Feb 26, 2021."

Oh my dear God.

Open original post on X

9:18:07 AM ET | Status 2112896213150257494

"How long can sperm cells survive inside a vaginal cavity?"

"For someone who is alive, 5 days. For someone who is dead, the literature says about 34 days."

"What about the oral cavity?"

"24 hours for someone who is alive. For someone is dead, about 4 days."

"When were the swaps collected form Ms. Birchmore's body?"

"Feb 26, 2021."

Damn you Brian Tully and John Fanning. Damn you to hell.

Open original post on X

9:18:50 AM ET | Status 2112896391659827238

"Did you test Ms. Birchmore's body for the presence of DNA?"

"Yes, there was none on her body itself."

"What about on her underwear?"

"Yes, we found semen."

"What did you do next?"

"I sent that sample to DNA for testing."

"Do you try to find sperm cells at that time?"

"Yes."

Open original post on X

9:20:56 AM ET | Status 2112896921106887047

"You also test for saliva?"

"Yes, via amylase."

"And if an item tests positive for amylase, what can it be?"

"It is presumptive positive for saliva but it can also be urine, feces or breast milk."

"What steps did you take to test Ms. Birchmore's underwear."

"I did a visual inspection for stains. Then I used an ALS, or alternate light source, like a black light. It helps me see stains I can't see with my naked eye. Then I documented those stains. Then I did a screen test, the AP test, for semen. I did the test where I did ALS positive indication. Anything that was AP positive, I did an extraction for sperm cells and semen."

"Exhibit 307 please."

Open original post on X

9:22:08 AM ET | Status 2112897222731768192

"What is exhibit 307?"

"This is a copy of the notes pages I generated while processing Ms. Birchmore's underwear."

We are now looking at images of Sandra's underwear.

There is semen on all sides of the underwear. On the top left back, middle back, bottom lower left back, under the vaginal area, and on six spots across the front.

Open original post on X

9:24:21 AM ET | Status 2112897782717566997

"Did you send these samples to the DNA section of your lab?"

"Yes."

Now we see a close up of the front of Sandra's underwear.

There is stain A in the top front right. ALS positive, AP test negative.

Center area near the crotch. Stain B was ALS positive. There was stain B-1 and b-2 that were AP

positive. I then took my extractions from there.

"What were you trying to determine?"

"If sperm cells were present, and neither had determinative results."

Open original post on X

9:25:26 AM ET | Status 2112898054474887599

"What about the back of the underwear?"

"The exterior back had part of stain b and also stain c and d."

"Stain E was also there?"

"Yes, stain e is the top back right, it was ALS and AP positive."

"Were there sperm cells detected?"

"Yes, on stain e."

"What did you do next?"

"I cut out the entire stain and took a sample of it for DNA testing."

Open original post on X

9:26:56 AM ET | Status 2112898433426083938

"What steps did you take to examine the interior front?"

"On the interior front, you can see stain f, stain g, bottom left and stain h, right side. All three were ALS positive. My AP testing was negative for all 3 of those stains."

"What steps did you do on the interior back of Ms. Birchmore's underwear?"

"I could see stain D and E, and I found stain I, which was interior back upper left side, as it's worn. All three were AP negative so I did no further testing."

Wow, only one single sperm sample survived!

Wow!

Burn in hell, Brian Tully and John Fanning.

Open original post on X

9:28:13 AM ET | Status 2112898755028750742

The witness explains how debris gathers on a slide when doing DNA testing and, also, how the testing is done to avoid that debris (microscopic degree).

"What is this?"

"This is my notes on the interior crotch section of Ms. Birchmore's underwear."

Open original post on X

9:29:37 AM ET | Status 2112899108943872133

"What further tests did you do on the inside crotch?"

"I also found stain J, and I did ALS testing. My AP testing was negative however, per lab protocol, I still did extractions, so that black box that says J1 and J2, that is were I checked for the presence of sperm cells."

"What were your results?"

"No sperm cells in J1."

"What about J-2?"

"I found sperm cells."

"What did you do next?"

"I cut out a portion of the underwear, preserved J-2, sampled it and sent it for testing."

Open original post on X

9:33:32 AM ET | Status 2112900091115700586

"What do you do when you collect skin cells?"

"I run a scalpel, then I take a swap, then I rub a sample collection swap over the same area, then I collect any scrapings, then I swap the scalpel itself, then I put all of that into the sample kit."

Open original post on X

9:33:57 AM ET | Status 2112900195784491190

"What areas did you examine?"

"I looked at the areas that were not around Ms. Birchmore's neck to see if there was any DNA that did not belong to Ms. Birchmore."

Open original post on X

9:46:37 AM ET | Status 2112903383732359393

"Let me ask you a question; if a sperm cell is present, and if you know, if there is then a mixture, do you know what a mixture is?"

"Objection."

"Counsel, sustained, back up in your questioning."

Open original post on X

9:46:55 AM ET | Status 2112903461952196666

"The presence of semen doesn't tell you who contributed the DNA right?"

"Right."

Open original post on X

9:49:18 AM ET | Status 2112904061347352922

"Is finding DNA on a surface....that might mean someone touched it?"

"Objection."

"Sustained."

"Did you observe any swaps of any surfaces from Ms. Birchmore's apartment?"

"No I did not."

"And you were shown the strap around the doorknob?"

"yes."

"Was the doorknob ever swapped or fingerprinted?"

"Not to my knowledge. I don't know."

"But crime scene services has the capacity to do fingerprinting?"

"Yes."

Open original post on X

9:49:37 AM ET | Status 2112904141093704087

"Did you observe any swaps of any surfaces from Ms. Birchmore's apartment?"

"No I did not."

"And you were shown the strap around the doorknob?"

"yes."

"Was the doorknob ever swapped or fingerprinted?"

"Not to my knowledge. I don't know."

"But crime scene services has the capacity to do fingerprinting?"

"Yes."

Shame on you, Brian Tully and John Fanning. Shame!

Open original post on X

10:02:39 AM ET | Status 2112907417914868155

"Nothing further."

Open original post on X

10:03:17 AM ET | Status 2112907580288983504

"Recross."

"Yes, your honor."

"Do you look at a photo and say, that's hair so I'm not going to bother with trace testing."

"Objection."

"Sustained as to form."

"What role do assumptions play in your job as a scientists."

"Objection."

"Sustained as to form."

Open original post on X

10:04:47 AM ET | Status 2112907958568820836

"When you saw hair on the strap did you assume it was Sandra Birchmore's?"

"No, I made no assumptions, I didn't even know if it was hair, I just collected it."

"And that's because assumptions aren't science?"

"Objection."

"Overruled."

"I have scientific methods when doing my testing. I don't make assumptions."

"Was the strap still around Ms. Birchmore's neck when she was transported from the scene."

"Yes."

"Thank you nothing further."

"You may step down."

Open original post on X

New witness - identity not yet clear in this pull

Editorial heading only: Grant's retrieved posts resume with expert testimony concerning childhood sexual abuse and grooming, but this interim pull does not contain a Grant-authored post naming the witness. No identity is inferred here.

10:19:29 AM ET | Status 2112911655206294014

"How do instances of childhood sexual abuse happen?"

"It's normally a pattern. The most common way is deception, coercion and manipulation as opposed to overt physical force."

Open original post on X

10:20:41 AM ET | Status 2112911960240988242

"You said it is anyone under the age of 18?"

"Yes, that's the definition in the literature."

"Are preps strangers or people known to the victim?"

"80% are known to the victim."

"What is the term used for this behavior?"

"Grooming."

"What is grooming?"

"Grooming is a deceptive and manipulative process used by sexual abuse preparators which is exploited to develop a relationship with the intended or targeted victim."

Open original post on X

10:29:21 AM ET | Status 2112914139945287693

"What about positions of trust?"

"Yes, that ties into the third stage, they are more likely to be able to build trust via the 1 on 1 relationship with the child, but also their position within an institution or their position. Doctor, police officer, attorney. Anyone who has additional power, opportunity or respect that will give them greater access, greater trust of the child, or greater trust of the community. Often perps will hold themselves out as pillars of the community. They may be known to be great with kids. They will form bonds with the victim's family members so the family will let the child stay around the adult more often as a trust person. They do that with the child, too."

That is sickening.

Open original post on X

10:29:36 AM ET | Status 2112914201174053203

Burn in hell.

All of you monsters.

Burn.

Open original post on X

Donyea Holloway - call announcement and morning break

10:46:48 AM ET | Status 2112918528802120126

"The government calls Donyea Holloway!"

Former Stoughton PD explorer participant alongside Sandra Birchmore.

"Your honor we have a delay with the witness arriving, can we ask for the break early?"

"Sure, jurors we will take our 20 minutes now. Your snacks are upstairs."

Morning break!

Open original post on X

10:47:56 AM ET | Status 2112918817445671145

"Anything else?"

"Your honor, we are flying through witnesses. We are ahead of schedule as to where we expected to be. We expected a little bit more time on the first two. We have Hallow, McGrath and Barrett. We have two more witnesses today. Chandler and Dan Barber."

Open original post on X

Donyea Holloway - testimony

Editorial organization: Grant announced Donyea Holloway as the next witness immediately before the morning break and reported a delay in the witness's arrival. The later testimony is grouped here based on that thread sequence; the retrieved posts at 11:29 do not independently restate the witness's name.

11:29:02 AM ET | Status 2112929158917468454

"Did you stay in touch with Sandra?"

"It was hard, but I tried. I joined the Navy right out of high school."

"Did you move back to Massachusetts?"

"Yes, I moved back to Massachusetts and became a Nay recruiter in the Quincy officer."

Oh no. Jayson Pickard was a recruiter there for the Army!

Open original post on X

11:29:47 AM ET | Status 2112929349510766623

"Did you stay in touch with Sandra after 2017?"

"Yes."

"Did she eventually tell you she was pregnant?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"I don't recall."

"Would looking at some text messages help refresh your recollection?"

"Yes."

"Read this to yourself please."

Open original post on X

11:31:28 AM ET | Status 2112929771751415896

"Does that refresh your recollection?"

"Yes."

"When did Sandra Birchmore disclose to you that she was pregnant?"

"In December of 2020."

"What, if anything, did Ms. Birchmore disclose to you about the father of her unborn baby?"

"She told me, do you remember the twins, and I said yea, and I said yea, and she said, yea I have been seeing him and he's the father."

"Did you affirmatively tell you the father was Matthew Farwell?"

"Yes."

"Did she tell you how she felt?"

"She was excited. Ecstatic. She was happy and wanted to have her baby."

Open original post on X

Source & Editorial Notes

- Primary-source limitation: factual courtroom narrative in this reconstruction is limited to posts authored by @GrantSmithEllis. Other users' posts are not used as report content.
- Retrieval: this first interim version uses the union of the uploaded October 21 live-thread and 500-post timeline snapshots. Records were recursively checked for Grant-authored quoted originals, deduplicated by X status ID, and ordered in Eastern Time.
- Completeness check: 50 Grant-authored reporting entries are reproduced through 11:31:28 AM ET. The live-thread pull alone omitted several Grant posts that were recovered from the timeline or from Grant's own quote-post objects; the union-of-pulls rule therefore materially improved this checkpoint.
- Replies: Grant-authored replies are retained when they continue, expand, or document courtroom reporting. The 11:07:59 AM and 11:08:08 AM greetings to viewers were excluded as social chatter. Retweets are excluded from report content.
- Quote-post handling: Grant-authored quote-posts are retained when they add materially distinct contemporaneous reporting or commentary. Pure duplicate/truncated quote-posts are not repeated; when a quoted Grant original was missing as a top-level record, the embedded original was recovered and preserved under its own status ID.
- Witness headings are editorial organization only. Stephanie Waite is named by Grant. The grooming/childhood-sexual-abuse witness is not named in this interim pull and is therefore left unidentified. The later Donyea Holloway heading is based on Grant's immediately preceding call announcement and delay report.
- Original wording: Grant's retrieved wording, spelling, capitalization, punctuation, and apparent typographical errors are preserved rather than silently corrected.
- Intervals with no Grant-authored post are not reconstructed. Silence in the retrieved corpus is not treated as proof that no courtroom activity occurred.
- Exhibits: under the current court-order breakpoint, this report does not attempt to acquire, reconcile, classify, or embed newly referenced exhibits. Grant's textual descriptions and exhibit references remain part of his reproduced reporting.
- Volume sanity check: no significant low-volume alert is triggered at this first interim checkpoint. Because the court day is still in progress, historical daily-volume comparison is treated only as a pace check; the full anomaly test will be repeated before the final report is declared complete.
- Interim cutoff: the latest non-duplicate Grant-authored reporting entry retained in this checkpoint is status 2112929771751415896 at 11:31:28 AM ET. Later proceedings are not represented here and this document must not be treated as a completed court-day record.

Support the reporting

This archive is made possible by Grant Smith Ellis's excellent on-the-ground courtroom reporting and his permission to use that work in this project. If you've found the reporting useful and would like to support his work directly:

Venmo · PayPal

All donations go directly to Grant Smith Ellis; this archive is unaffiliated with and receives no proceeds from them.